

DIGITAL KILLER

SYNOPSIS

Morris Smith is a middle-aged euthanasia specialist. One day, on his birthday, his closest friend gives him a vacation memory as a gift. At the end of this memory, its original owner kills someone and Morris finds that he enjoys it immensely. Death becomes an obsession for him, and he becomes trapped between real life and memories. He tries to kill people himself but is too afraid of going to prison. In the end, he kills himself.

TREATMENT

Morris Smith is thirty-five years old, no longer finds any joy in life, and lives alone. He is a euthanasia specialist.

In the opening scenes we see Morris go through several euthanasia sessions back to back; each one unfolding almost identically, like a procedure on an assembly line. The patient is given a sedative injection, forms are signed, the line on the monitor flattens, Morris checks his watch and logs the time. His face is expressionless; he moves as if he's working on a factory line. Even when a patient's relatives break down crying, Morris's response never goes beyond a mechanical "my condolences." At night he goes home, leaves his dinner half-eaten in front of the TV, and falls asleep.

These scenes are cut together as short vignettes, montage-style, conveying Morris's emotional numbness through repetition rather than exposition. In the final vignette, as a patient dies, something very brief, almost imperceptible, crosses Morris's face; a slight raise of an eyebrow, a moment's hesitation.

His coworkers think he needs a vacation. On his thirty-sixth birthday, he celebrates with a few colleagues from work. His closest friend, John, is also there. John tells him he bought him a vacation memory to help him relax. Morris is thrilled and says he'll use it after the birthday party. Once everyone has left, Morris plugs the chip containing the memory into the socket behind his ear and enters a trance state. He opens his eyes walking along a beach. He feels deeply peaceful and calm. There is no one around him. He continues walking along the shore for a while. Up ahead, past some rocks, he sees a couple. He approaches them and greets them. He smiles and looks around. Once he's sure no one else is there, he pulls a gun from his waist and kills the couple. At that moment, Morris wakes with a start in real life. He realizes he has had an orgasm. He removes the chip from his head and throws it aside. He washes his face and hands and collapses onto the bed. He falls asleep wondering why killing someone gave him so much pleasure.

While putting another patient to sleep in the lab, he imagines killing them simply because he wants to. He leaves the lab and goes to the bathroom, where he masturbates. Afterward he goes to find John and asks him where he got the gift. John says he bought it from MemoryLeak, a very expensive and well-known company, but Morris says he doesn't believe him, he points out that the memory has glitches and doesn't end where it should. He tells John that if he doesn't clearly say who he really got the memory from, they'll both be in trouble. John

confesses the truth: unable to afford MemoryLeak's prices, he actually bought it from an illegal source that sells memories far cheaper, and he describes to Morris where to find it. After work, Morris goes to this place; an underpass market. He enters a dark shop, where he tells the owner that John described this place to him and recounts what he's experienced. The man asks what he needs. He mentions that he has all kinds of memories available, without limits. Morris asks for more killer memories. He buys them. On his way home he feels both a pang of guilt and happiness. He goes to his room and puts the memory on.

One night Morris finds himself walking aimlessly through the streets. He notices a stranger walking alone and, driven by some impulse, begins following him; his steps seem to be unconsciously replaying the beach memory. By the side of the road, in front of a construction site, he notices a heavy piece of scrap metal and picks it up. When the stranger turns down an empty street, Morris closes the distance, gripping the metal tightly. Just as he's about to raise his arm, the red light of a security camera mounted at the entrance of the building across the street catches his eye. His hands start to shake, his breathing quickens. He drops the metal and backs away into the darkness.

The next day at work, that moment from the night before is still on his mind but it also whispers a different idea to him: a way to kill without consequence is already within his reach. We see Morris laughing in the lab (the first time in the film he's shown laughing) as a new patient arrives. He begins talking with the patient. The patient says he doesn't want to die, but doesn't want to keep living like this either. Without realizing it, this line triggers a desire in Morris. The scene is deliberately built to echo the euthanasia vignettes from the film's opening: same room, same procedure, same movements... But now something inside Morris has completely changed. In contrast to the distant, neutral shots of the opening, the camera moves in close on Morris this time: his breathing, the glint in his eyes, the faint smile forming at the corner of his mouth. He repeats the same mechanical gesture of checking his watch and logging the time, but now he moves not like someone counting minutes, but like someone savoring a moment. As he persuades the patient toward death, his voice; unlike the flat, procedural tone of the opening scenes takes on an almost tender, secretly excited quality. He carries out the euthanasia procedure. Even though he's afraid to kill someone in real life, the pleasure he gets from being able to do this through his profession intoxicates him.

Some time later, we see Morris having a breakdown in his bathroom at home. Killing one person is no longer enough for him, and he begins thinking more deeply about death itself. He talks about wanting to understand death by killing himself, but he's still too afraid to actually do it. He goes back to the memory shop and buys the final moments of someone who died by suicide. As the shopkeeper sells him this memory, he gives Morris a strange look but says nothing. Morris returns home and goes to his bedroom. At night, he puts the memory on and begins living it. He finds himself inside the memory of a woman preparing to cut her wrist in the shower. He looks at her trembling hands, the razor, the bathtub. He listens to the sound of her sobbing and crying. He feels the pain the woman feels. Then, with a scream, the woman cuts her wrist. Morris, feeling a flash of pain, flinches in real life. He then feels the body growing cold. He feels the blood slowly flowing. He recalls that a writer once did the same thing in the past. As the woman's eyes wander around the bathroom, we see a picture of Beşir Fuad. The woman's eyes slowly close, and she dies.

He comes out of the memory but doesn't let go of the chip for a while; he lives the same memory over and over, and the line between real time and the memory blurs. For days he doesn't set foot outside his home. He doesn't answer calls from work, keeps his phone on silent. When he looks in the mirror, he feels as though he's facing a face he no longer recognizes. The curtains stay drawn, the apartment gradually falls into disarray. One morning he removes the memory chip from his head for the last time and sets it down on the table; there's no longer any urge to kill in him, nor any fear. Only a deep emptiness remains.

Morris walks into the bathroom in a state of numbness and emptiness. He picks up paper and pen. He slowly cuts his wrist and begins writing down what he feels. As he's describing what he's feeling, he hears a knock at the door. He turns his head and looks at the door, but doesn't answer. In his eyes there's a flicker of regret and, faintly, hope. A sense that he's made a mistake. He raises his arm into the air so the blood will flow faster. His eyes slowly close, and he dies.